



founded on the margin of difference the side created with spin, with both bat and ball.

This era of dominance sprang into existence in the aftermath of a startling defeat to England in 2012.

English spinners Graeme Swann and Monty Panesar combined for 37 wickets in the four-match series. The duo unsettled the Indian batting line-up, barring Cheteshwar Pujara, as England secured a 2-1 win.

England's spinners averaged 28.61 in the series, while the home tweakers went at 40.62, a key divergence that determined the fate of the contest. The away side's batting charge was led by opener Alistair Cook, who amassed three centuries on the way to 562 runs from eight innings. Kevin Pietersen had a strong tour too, scoring 338 runs, including a stunning 186 at the Wankhede.

The ruins of this defeat pushed India into a forced transition, in which it found the pieces to build the winning machine it would eventually become.

Ashwin, who was part of that series, was soon joined by Ravindra Jadeja, and they quickly formed one of the most devastating spin duos in the history of Test cricket.

During India's winning run at home, Ashwin and Jadeja collected a combined 539 wickets at just 20.18

runs apiece.

With time, the pair refined their batting to the point that they came to be regarded as genuine all-rounders, offering significant steel to the Indian lower middle order.

Meanwhile, Ajinkya Rahane joined Virat Kohli and Pujara to form a middle-order trio that provided India with substantial stability.

Their aptitude in negotiating spin, along with Ashwin and Jadeja's sharpness with the ball, allowed India to keep visiting sides at arm's length in home Tests.

Australia, in 2016/17, was the only team to come close to bridging this gap in the period, running India

BATTING AGAINST SPIN FROM JAN 2013 TO SEP 2024

Virat Kohli

5905 runs
(58.89 average)

Cheteshwar Pujara

3055 (66.41)

Ajinkya Rahane

2263 (41.90)

Old grammar: Cheteshwar Pujara steps out with the calm assurance that once defined India's mastery of spin. In a series that exposed how far that certainty has faded, his method now feels like a relic from a more assured age. K. R. DEEPAK

close in an intense series that finished 2-1.

Narrowing gap

The arrival of the World Test Championship in 2021 brought with it a need for more decisive results, prompting India to dial up its home advantage through pitches that began to spin square from Day 1.

What this did, unwittingly, was minimise the gap in skill between Indian spinners and visiting ones. This, in turn, made life harder for Indian batters, allowing away teams a stronger foothold in contests.

After losing just once in 34 Tests from 2013 to 2019, India went on to lose three of its next 19. Despite these stutters, India maintained its strong home record, pipping England and Australia following stiff battles.

However, the fault lines were evident and were eventually exploited by New Zealand late in 2024. The Kiwis became the first team in 12 years to overturn the spin gap, as they claimed a 3-0 series